Coping with Stress in Adolescents

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Introduction

Stress is a response to external or internal challenges, pressures, or events. Stress that motivates is called eustress and stress that paralyses and affects various domains of functioning is called distress. Adolescence being a period of transition from child to adulthood there are many challenges that will cause stress in normal adolescents. In specially challenged adolescents their problems will be exacerbated with challenges of adolescent period. These are outlined in **Figure 1**.

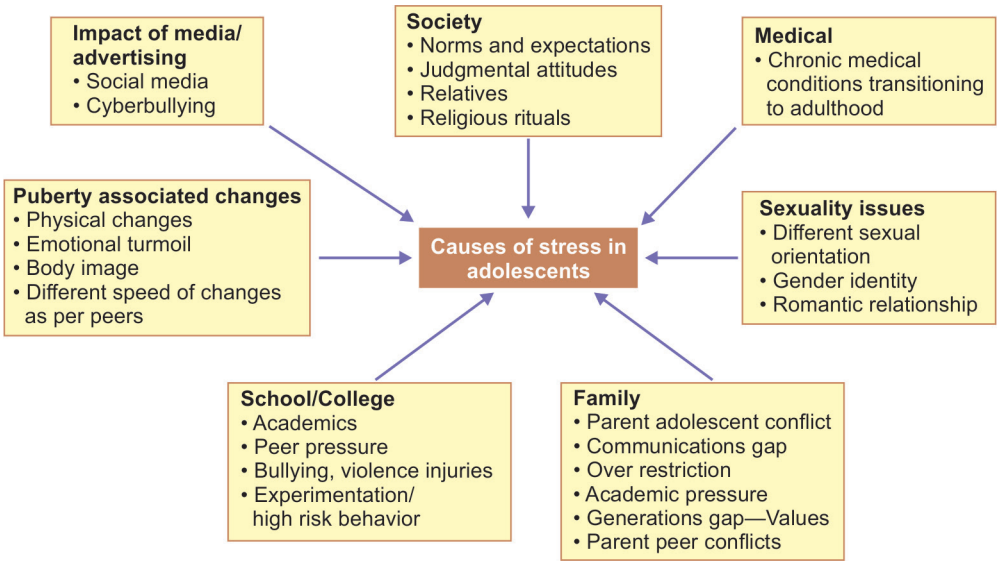

Fig. 1: Causes of stress.

Assessment of Stress

This can be done by taking a detailed history of various factors:

- ☑ Effect on sleep (quantity/quality and duration)
- ☑ Effect on food habits (overeating/anorexia, binge eating, and emotional eating excess junk food)
- ☑ Effects on personality (withdrawn/noncommunicative/irritable/frequent temper out bursts)
- ☑ Effects on relationships (conflict at home—family or school—teachers/peers)
- ☑ Effects on academic performance (lack of interest in studying and or deterioration in marks)
- ☑ History of addictions/or unproductive ways to deal with stress **(Table 1)**

TABLE 1: Addictions/unproductive ways to deal with stress.

☑ Alcohol	☑ Trying not to think about it
☑ Tobacco	☑ Avoidance
☑ Internet use	☑ Isolating
☑ Gaming	☑ Arguments
☑ Drugs	☑ Blaming/criticizing oneself

Screening and Counseling Methods for Primary Care Clinicians

- ☑ HEEADSSS (Goldenring and Rosen, 2004)
  - Home, education, eating, activities, drugs, sexuality, suicide/depression, and safety
- ☑ SHADESS (Ginsburg, 2007b)
  - This is a modification of the HEEADSSS interview
  - SHADESS stands for school, home, activities, drugs/substance use, emotions/depression, sexuality, and safety
- ☑ BATHE (Lieberman and Stuart, 1999)
  - This is a brief supportive interviewing technique, adapted from psychotherapy
  - BATHE stands for background, affect, troubling, handling, and empathy

Adolescent Education/Parental Guidance (Table 2)

Teaching Resilience

Adults—parents and teachers can play a great role by teaching children to become resilient. This will help them deal with all adversities in life as adolescents and young adult (AYA) and adulthood and promote positive mental health.

- ☑ This can be done by developing coping skills with programs like the World Health Organization (WHO) life skills and increasing their emotional quotient so that they take stress as a challenge to overcome and not go into anxiety and depression.
- ☑ Developing positive mindset and positive self-talk.

Focus on Healthy Lifestyle—Healthy Body Leads to Healthy Mind

- ☑ Daily minimum 45 minutes of good physical activity/exercise. Exercise induces endorphins which promotes feeling of happiness and promotes neuronal activity.
- ☑ Focus on adequate sleep with good sleep routines. Adequate sleep generates good neurotransmitters that help deal with stress.
- ☑ Dietary habits with good breakfast, ensuring balanced diet and minimum of caffeine and junk food.

Teaching Good Relaxation Techniques

- ☑ Mindfulness, meditation, chanting, prayers, deep breathing, Tai Chi, yoga, pranayama, progressive muscular relaxation (PMR), visual imagery, biofeedback, etc.
- ☑ Developing healthy stress busters such as sports, exercise, music, and art

Practicing with Case Scenarios with Parents/Peers

- ☑ Practicing stress inducing scenarios to develop coping mechanism, e.g., mock exams
- ☑ Setting specific developing skills to handle various stress generating situations
- ☑ Developing ability to resist peer pressure and assertiveness to say No to situations, and actions adolescent is not comfortable with

TABLE 2: What helps when you are in stress?

Situation	***What happens***	***What it does***	***Results***	***Behavior***
Severe stress	"Emotional storm"	Experience intensely difficult thoughts and feelings. They are so strong they are like a mighty storm, and they can easily overpower you	Difficult thoughts and feelings hook us, and we are pulled away from our values	Your thoughts and actions not under your control
		What are the solutions		
Actions	What happens	What is does	Results	Behavior
Ground yourself	Helps calms you down	Brings yourself back to stable mind	Rational thinking enabled	Emotional hijacks avoided
Practice empathy	You understand and notice pain in yourself and others	You respond with kindness	Better interpersonal relationship handling reduces stress	Calm behavior—better results
Unhooking from stress and making make room for positive thoughts	☑ You notice the difficult thought or feeling with curiosity ☑ You can name the difficult thought or feeling	☑ Refocus on what you are doing ☑ Engage fully in the activity at hand	☑ Pay full attention to whoever is with you and whatever you are doing ☑ You can rationally analyze	You can allow the painful feeling or thought to come and go like the weather
Acting on your values	Remember the values inculcated in you. If you have responsibility for caring for others, what kind of person do you want to be	You bring out your positivity loving, wise, attentive, committed, persistent, protective, courageous	These are values which we must aspire to inculcate in yourself	More positive behavior

Source: World Health Organization (2020). Doing What Matters in Times of Stress: An Illustrated Guide. [online] Available from https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240003927. [Last accessed November, 2022].

Further Reading

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Lead Author
Ram Gulati

Co-Authors
Balaji J, Ravi Rathod

Under the Auspices of the IAP Action Plan 2022

Remesh Kumar R
IAP President 2022

Upendra Kinjawadekar
IAP President-Elect 2022

Piyush Gupta
IAP President 2021

Vineet Saxena
IAP HSG 2022–2023

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IAP Standard Treatment Guidelines Committee

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Remesh Kumar R

IAP Coordinator

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